

Applying for a Job

When you find a job listing for a role that interests you, and for which you are well qualified, it's time to consider how to apply for the job. Navigating a company's application process can be tricky, however, each company has its own procedures. If you read carefully and consider your application materials thoughtfully, you can make an application that stands out.

How would you do that?

First, read the listing to see whether the company prefers to fill an online application, for example, LinkedIn. Next, send a resume and cover letter to an email address, or follow other procedure. Follow the directions very carefully and do exactly as they say. If you don't, your application may get disqualified and may never be seen by the company's hiring managers.

Generally speaking, there is no limit to the number of applications an aspiring candidate can submit, especially if the job search targets different companies. However, some companies limit the number of applications you can send in a particular time period, so you'll need to be strategic in that case and choose the jobs that are the most interesting to you.

There may be other strategic considerations. When you are interested in multiple positions within a company, then it's better to focus on one application. However, applying for multiple open positions can depend on several factors. One factor could be to apply first for the position you believe you are most qualified for or that interests you most. After applying, contact human resources (HR) or a hiring manager to ask for advice about whether you should apply for each job you are interested in or if it's best to avoid duplicate application submissions. They should be able to tell you whether your application can be forwarded or whether the company allows you to create a profile that lets you easily apply for multiple jobs.

Resume and cover letter

In almost every case, you'll need to send a resume, and in most cases you should send a cover letter, even if it isn't required. If you've already drafted basic versions of these two documents, you're in a good position. You'll need to edit them to fit each job, but you won't need to start from scratch. Work carefully and make sure you include information that shows your skills and experience to advance each specific role.

- **Resume** – Double-check for these potential problems and any others you may spot:
 - Outdated or missing contact information
 - Grammatical and formatting errors
 - Using an unprofessional email address
 - Cliche vocabulary or jargon
 - Unrelated job experience or irrelevant hobbies
 - Attaching a photo of yourself (your resume should not contain a photo)
- **Cover letter** – Be careful to check for these issues:
 - Grammatical and formatting errors
 - Too long (multiple pages) or too brief
 - Addressing the wrong person or misspelling a name
 - Not tailoring the letter to the specific company and job opening
 - Tone is arrogant or too humble—try for a professional, confident tone
 - Listing references in the letter
 - Explaining the reason(s) why you are no longer working for your previous employer or including other issues that will be better to discuss in an interview if necessary

Other application materials

In addition to a copy of your resume and cover letter, a potential employer may request other documents to validate your qualifications such as educational transcripts, writing samples, portfolios, certifications, a list of your references, and letters of recommendation. Supporting documentation will vary among hiring companies and job positions. Be sure to follow all the instructions provided by the company to avoid submitting an incomplete job application.

- **List of references** – Look out for some common mistakes applicants make with their lists:
 - Providing it too early (if it is not requested, save it for later in the screening process)
 - Failing to notify your references that they may be contacted by hiring employers
 - Providing incorrect contact information
- **Letters of recommendation** – Avoid presenting a letter with the following errors:
 - Too vague or generic content
 - Lacking information that validates your work
 - Any letter that expresses reservations, especially if it is not counterbalanced with mentioning any positive qualities
- **School/college transcripts** – Do not provide a copy of your transcripts if the hiring company has stated that you must request a sealed copy be sent directly to them by the educational institution.
- **Online portfolio's URL** – Verify that the URL is correct and that the link is valid and provides work samples that are recent and properly documented.
- **Work or writing samples** – Check for these common errors:
 - Grammatical errors
 - Does not show your work effectively

- Cliches or overuse of buzzwords
- Too brief or too lengthy
- **Certifications (trainings, licenses, and others)** – Verify these features:
 - Valid signatures, seals, or logos are present
 - If the certificate includes an expiration date, make sure it is still current
 - Only include relevant certificates that support your academic or experiential qualifications for the job position

Document naming and organization:

Before uploading a PDF or other formatted files, make sure that you have used a consistent naming convention for your files. Include your full name as part of the file names. For example, if your resume is in an electronic file with the name "John_Smith-Resume.pdf", then name the rest of your supporting documents as "John_Smith-Cover_Letter.pdf". This helps the recruiter identify all the files that were submitted by you.

Use the following rule of thumb: name your files consistently and in a way that, if sorted alphabetically, all of your files will remain together in a file search. For example:

Name	Date modified	Size	Kind
John_Smith-Cover_Letter.pdf	April 4, 2022 at 2:20 PM	302 KB	PDF Document
John_Smith-References.pdf	March 14, 2022 at 2:44 PM	45 KB	PDF Document
John_Smith-Resume.pdf	May 12, 2022 at 8:01 AM	224 KB	PDF Document
John_Smith-Transcripts.pdf	May 3, 2022 at 3:02 PM	362 KB	PDF Document

Limit your special characters to underscores and/or hyphens. If you incorporate blank spaces in your file names, be sure to use them consistently. Don't include version numbers as part of your file names and be sure to submit all of the requested documents at once.

It may be convenient to create a template for your cover letters. Include your name, job title, and contact information. Use a cover letter you have already written and identify the customized information. Highlight it to ease the process of tailoring a subsequent letter for a different position title or company. Save the template letter with the word "template" included in its name and use it as needed. Once a new tailored letter is written and ready, save the file, replacing the word "template" with the name of the company or the job title you are applying for.

Conclusion

Remember that a cover letter is a one-time opportunity to create a first impression. In one page, you must provide information about your qualifications and career aspirations in a way that compels recruiters to learn more about how your skills and experience, and to see if your goals align with the company's own mission and goals. It is equally important to include quality content in your letter as it is to present it free from unfortunate, but very common, errors found among online job applications today. Correctness and accuracy in all of your supporting documents complete the image you project and will help you stand out from the competition.
